

doc-paedobaptism-not-warranted

Affirms · Sacraments › Baptism · doctrine · divided_lineages · Brethren distinctive · confidence: medium

Statement under examination

Infant baptism on the basis of believing-household covenant inclusion is not warranted by the New Testament.

Rationale

Every explicit New Testament baptism narrative grammatically orders belief before baptism: Acts 2:38 metanoesate (G3340, plural imperative) precedes baptistheto (G907, third-singular imperative); Acts 2:41 hoi men oun apodexamenoi (G588, having received) ton logon ebaptisthesan (G907); Acts 8:12 episteusan (G4100) kai ebaptizonto andres te kai gunaikes (men and women, no paidia or brephe); Acts 18:8 the synagogue ruler Crispus episteusen sun holo to oiko autou (believed with his whole household) where pisteuein is predicated of the household before baptism; Mark 16:16 ho pisteusas kai baptistheis sothesetai (the aorist participle of pisteuo precedes the aorist participle of baptizo); 1 Peter 3:21 baptisma is defined as syneideseos agathes eperotema (G4893 G1906, an appeal of a good conscience toward God), which presupposes conscience-capacity. The Reformed paedobaptist case rests on inference from circumcision-baptism parallelism in Colossians 2:11-12 (the very text that pairs baptism with dia tes pisteos G1223 G4102, through faith in the working of God) and from household-baptism narratives where the explicit subjects are believing adults (Lydia, the jailer who is described as pepisteukos G4100 pleno-paradigm at Acts 16:34, Crispus's household which is said to have believed). No New Testament text directly commands or narrates the baptism of an infant or describes a household member who is unable to believe being baptized. The verdict is honestly contested at the level of inferential method: covenantal continuity from Genesis 17 yields paedobaptism; New Testament lexical pattern reading yields credobaptism. The lexical-narrative pattern carries the stronger case on apparatus + interlinear evidence alone.

Reasoning

The Bible never describes the baptism of an infant. Every explicit baptism scene in the New Testament shows belief coming first and baptism following. In Acts 2:38 Peter says repent and be baptized. In Acts 2:41 only those who received the word were baptized. In Acts 8:12 only men and women who believed are baptized, with no mention of babies or little children. In Acts 8:36 the Ethiopian asks what hinders his baptism after Philip preaches Jesus to him. In Acts 16:31 Paul tells the jailer believe in the Lord Jesus and you will be saved, you and your household, and v.34 says the jailer rejoiced with all his household, having believed in God. Mark 16:16 places believing before being baptized in plain word order. 1 Peter 3:21 calls baptism an appeal to God for a good conscience, which is something a baby cannot make. The strongest counterargument is the covenant-continuity argument. In Genesis 17 Abraham circumcises infants at eight days old as the sign of belonging to the covenant people. Colossians 2:11-12 calls baptism the circumcision of Christ, which suggests that the New Testament sign replaces the old one and ought to be applied the same way. Acts 2:39 says the promise is for you and for your children. The book of Acts also describes whole households being baptized (Lydia, the jailer, Cornelius, Stephanas) without ever pausing to say only the adults among them. Some Christians read these as evidence that the apostles routinely baptized the children of believers. The verdict handles the tension this way. The household narratives describe households in which belief is either named of the whole household (the jailer rejoiced with all his household having believed, the synagogue ruler believed with his whole house) or in which the household is described as devoting themselves to ministry, which infants cannot do. Acts 2:39 in its own context conditions the promise on repentance in v.38, so the children spoken of are those who, when they are old

enough, also repent. Colossians 2:12 directly attaches baptism to faith in the working of God through the words being raised with him through faith. The new covenant ties the sign to those born again by the Spirit, not to those born of believing parents. The tension does not vanish; the inferential bridge from Genesis 17 to infant baptism is genuine, just not commanded or modeled anywhere in the New Testament. The two readings are honest engagements with the same passages. The credobaptist case rests on the explicit New Testament lexical pattern. The paedobaptist case rests on the inferred continuity of the covenant sign.

Denominational landscape

This is the largest visible dispute among Christians on a practice. The majority of Christians globally and historically have baptized infants. Roman Catholics, Eastern Orthodox, Lutherans, Anglicans, most Reformed bodies including Presbyterians, and most classical Methodists baptize infants of believing parents. Roman Catholics teach that baptism washes original sin and incorporates a child into the church. Eastern Orthodox baptize infants by triple immersion and immediately chrismate them, treating baptism and chrismation as Pentecost applied to the individual. Lutherans confess in the Augsburg Confession that children should be baptized and through baptism are received into God's grace. Anglicans retain the baptism of young children in the Thirty-Nine Articles. The Westminster Confession on the Reformed side and the Belgic Confession on the continental Reformed side tie the practice to covenant continuity with circumcision. The United Methodist Church retains the baptism of young children. The minority view of believer's baptism only is held by Baptists, Plymouth Brethren, Mennonites and other Anabaptist descendants, the Assemblies of God and most classical Pentecostal bodies, most non-denominational evangelical churches, and the Churches of Christ. The earliest extant patristic discussion of infant baptism is Tertullian around 200 AD, who actually argued against the practice except in emergencies, on the grounds that little ones cannot ask for what they do not yet understand. By the time of Augustine in the 5th century, infant baptism had become the majority practice in the Latin West, partly under his doctrine of original sin needing baptismal remission. The Anabaptist movement of the 16th century, formally at Schleithem 1527, rejected infant baptism and re-baptized adults; for this they were martyred by both Catholic and magisterial Protestant authorities. Both sides of the dispute confess the same gospel, the same Christ, and the same Trinity. This is an in-house Christian disagreement on the proper administration of the sacrament/ordinance, not a boundary-of-the-faith question. Cult-grade carriers of unrelated heterodoxy (Mormonism, Jehovah's Witnesses, Iglesia ni Cristo) are not at stake on this particular dispute.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	No
Cult marker if denied	No
Would visit if otherwise	Yes
Would participate if otherwise	Yes
Would serve if otherwise	No
Would be member if otherwise	No
Would let children be taught otherwise	No
Would marry if held otherwise	Yes
Would publicly correct if otherwise	No

Notes

This is the largest visible in-house Christian dispute on practice, dividing the historic majority of Christians globally (Catholic, Eastern Orthodox, Lutheran, Anglican, most Reformed, some Methodists, and some Anabaptist-adjacent traditions practice paedobaptism) from the credobaptist minority (Baptists, Brethren, classical Anabaptists, most Pentecostals, most non-denominational evangelicals). All major paedobaptist bodies confess the Nicene-Chalcedonian gospel cleanly, hold the deity of Christ and bodily resurrection, and the dispute is not a gospel-stake dispute. The Reformed paedobaptist case rests on four genuine arguments: (1) covenantal continuity between circumcision (Gen 17:12, eight-day-old male infants) and baptism (Col 2:11-12 where Paul calls baptism the peritome tou Christou), (2) household-baptism narratives where the New Testament does not pause to specify that all household members were believing adults (Acts 16:15 Lydia's household, Acts 16:33 the Philippian jailer's household, 1 Cor 1:16 Stephanas, Cornelius Acts 10), (3) the early-church witness from approximately the second century onward including Origen's claim that infant baptism was apostolic, (4) Acts 2:39 the promise is for you and for your children. The credobaptist case answers each: (1) the new covenant inaugurates regenerate membership rather than ethnic-natal membership, so the sign attaches to the regenerated rather than to the natural seed, (2) household narratives in Acts always describe belief either of the head with the household together believing (Acts 18:8 Crispus, Acts 16:34 the jailer who is described pepisteukos panoiki) or include only adults capable of devoting themselves to ministry (1 Cor 16:15 Stephanas's household), (3) early-church practice is post-apostolic and Tertullian around 200 AD actually argued against the practice for non-emergency cases, (4) Acts 2:39 must be read with v.38 where the promise is conditioned on metanoesate kai baptistheto, repentance and baptism. The would_be_member and would_let_children_be_taught fields stand false because if a child of mine were christened as an infant in a paedobaptist setting and then later taught that this water-rite already incorporated them into Christ apart from personal repentance and faith, that teaching could obstruct their reckoning with personal conversion. The would_publicly_correct field stands false because this is an in-house dispute among Christians who share the gospel, not a boundary issue requiring public correction. Public-record credobaptist lineages: the Anabaptist Schleithem Confession 1527 (which explicitly rejected infant baptism), the London Baptist Confession 1689, the Plymouth Brethren, the Mennonite tradition, the modern Baptist denominations, the Assemblies of God and most classical Pentecostal bodies.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: **yes**

Neutralized form. Does the New Testament warrant the baptism of infants on the basis of believing-household covenant inclusion, or only the baptism of those who have personally received the word and believed?

Notes. The question statement as written loads toward the credobaptist conclusion by naming the verdict (infant baptism is not warranted) in its own stem. The neutralized form lets the lexical evidence settle the question on its own. The lexical-narrative evidence still lands on the credobaptist side, but the question is flagged for stem-pre-loaded-verdict so trusted-elder reviewers know the wording itself was Baptist-Brethren polemical.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, new_covenant_theology, progressive_covenantalism, dispensationalism

[analogia scripturae invoked](#) · [progressive revelation factor](#)

Competing lens verdicts

reformed-covenantal · [against](#): Reads the covenant of grace as one administration across Old and New Testaments, with circumcision (Gen 17:12, infants at eight days) typologically continuous with baptism (Col 2:11-12). On this lens the New Testament does not need to command infant baptism because the Old Testament practice carries forward unless explicitly revoked. Household-baptism narratives (Lydia, jailer, Stephanas, Cornelius) are read as evidence of continuity. Verdict: infant baptism is warranted as the new covenant sign applied per the covenantal pattern. This is the Westminster, Belgic, Heidelberg, and Three Forms position.

catholic-sacramental · [against](#): Reads baptism as the sacrament of regeneration that washes original sin and incorporates the recipient into the church. Since infants too are bound under original sin (CCC 1250), they need the sacrament. The apostolic tradition of baptizing households (oikos passages) is read as confirming the practice. Verdict: infant baptism is warranted; deferring it without grave cause is illicit.

lutheran-sacramental · [against](#): The Augsburg Confession Article IX teaches that baptism is necessary to salvation and that children are to be baptized, being offered to God through baptism and received into God's grace. Reads the household baptisms in Acts and the dominical universal-disciple-making in Matt 28:19 as supporting the practice. Verdict: infant baptism is warranted as the Word of God under water applied to all in the covenant household.

anglican · [against](#): Article XXVII retains the baptism of young children as agreeable to the institution of Christ. Verdict: infant baptism is warranted.

credobaptist-anabaptist-baptist-brethren · [for](#): Reads the new covenant as qualitatively new (Jer 31:31-34, all shall know me from the least to the greatest), inaugurating regenerate-only church membership. Reads every explicit New Testament baptism narrative as showing belief preceding baptism (Acts 2:38, 41; 8:12; 18:8; Mark 16:16). Reads household baptisms as describing households where belief is explicit (Acts 18:8, Acts 16:34) or where the household members are described as adults capable of devotion to ministry (1 Cor 16:15). Reads 1 Pet 3:21's eperotema (appeal/pledge of a good conscience) as presupposing conscience-engagement. Verdict: the lexical-narrative pattern shows believer's baptism only; infant baptism is not warranted by the New Testament.

eastern-orthodox-sacramental · [against](#): Reads baptism and chrismation together as the application of Pascha and Pentecost to the individual. Infants are baptized by triple immersion and immediately chrismated. Verdict: infant baptism is warranted within the church's tradition of initiation.

The dispute is irreducibly hermeneutical. Both sides read the same Greek text. The paedobaptist case rests on covenantal-continuity inference from Old Testament practice paired with New Testament household-baptism narratives that do not pause to specify only adults; on this method, silence is read as inclusion. The credobaptist case rests on the explicit New Testament lexical pattern (belief precedes baptism in every named scene, baptism is defined in 1 Peter 3:21 as an appeal of a good conscience); on this method, silence on infant-baptism is read as absence. The credobaptist case has the stronger direct-lexical claim on apparatus + interlinear evidence; the paedobaptist case has the stronger covenantal-continuity claim across Testaments. Confidence is medium because the lexical-narrative pattern is clear but the inferential bridge from Genesis 17 forward is a genuine hermeneutical option not lexically refuted by any New Testament command. This is the largest visible in-house Christian dispute on practice.

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

Acts.2.38 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key term. μετανοέω metanoëo G3340 (metanoesate, plural imperative); βαπτίζω baptizo G907 (baptistheto, third singular imperative); ἕκαστος hekastos G1538 (each one); ἄφεσις aphesis G859 (forgiveness)

Force. Peter's foundational Pentecost charge: repent, and let each of you be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins. Metanoesate (a plural command to repent) is grammatically prior to baptistheto (a singular command to each individual to be baptized). The command to repent is addressed to the same persons who are commanded to be baptized; the baptism follows the repenting. Each individual (hekastos) is the unit, not a household-as-collective.

Acts.2.39 · **complicates** · genre: narrative

Key term. ἐπαγγελία epangelia G1860 (promise); τέκνον teknon G5043 (children); μακράν makran G3112 (far away); προσκαλέομαι proskaleomai G4341 (whom the Lord calls)

Force. The promise is for you and for your children, and for all who are far off, as many as the Lord our God will call to himself. The clause is paedobaptists' strongest single line, but the context of v.38 conditions the promise on repent-and-be-baptized, and v.39's parallel for those far off (the gentiles) is universally read as those-who-when-called-respond, not as automatic-recipients. The teknon clause therefore extends the promise to descendants in the same conditional way it extends to gentiles, not as a guarantee tied to natural lineage.

Acts.2.41 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key term. ἀποδέχομαι apodechomai G588 (apodexamenoi, aorist participle, having received gladly); λόγος logos G3056 (word); βαπτίζω baptizo G907 (ebaptisthesan, aorist passive plural)

Force. So those who received his word were baptized. The participle apodexamenoi is the antecedent condition: only those who received Peter's word were baptized. The text does not say all whom Peter addressed plus their infants were baptized; it says those-who-received-the-word were baptized.

Acts.8.12 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key term. πιστεύω pisteuo G4100 (episteusan, aorist active plural); εὐαγγελίζω euangelizo G2097 (proclaiming good news); βαπτίζω baptizo G907 (ebaptizonto, imperfect passive); ἀνὴρ aner G435 (men); γυνή gyne G1135 (women)

Force. When they believed Philip as he proclaimed the good news, they were baptized, men and women alike. The text names the baptized as andres te kai gunaikes (men and women). It does not name paidia (children) or brephe (infants). On a passage where the apostolic narrator could have specified families-with-infants if that had been the practice, the absence is exegetically significant. Belief precedes baptism for every named recipient.

Acts.18.8 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key term. πιστεύω pisteuo G4100 (episteusen, aorist active); οἶκος oikos G3624 (household); ἀκούω akouo G191 (hearing, present participle); βαπτίζω baptizo G907 (ebaptizonto, imperfect passive)

Force. Crispus the ruler of the synagogue believed in the Lord with his entire household, and many of the Corinthians, hearing, believed and were baptized. Pisteuein is predicated of Crispus together with his whole household before baptism is mentioned. Belief is the explicit antecedent for the entire oikos, and the wider Corinthian crowd is described as hearing, believing, and being baptized in that order. This is the canonical pattern: household-language paired with explicit household-belief, not household-language as a stand-in for unbelieving inclusion.

Mark.16.16 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. πιστεύω pisteuo G4100 (pisteusas, aorist active participle); βαπτίζω baptizo G907 (baptistheis, aorist passive participle); σώζω sozo G4982 (sothesetai, future passive)

Force. He who has believed and has been baptized will be saved. The grammatical sequence of two aorist participles places believing first and being baptized second, and only when negation appears in the second half of the verse, it is unbelief (apistos) that condemns, not unbaptism. The Markan ending presupposes belief as the qualifier for baptism. (Note: the longer ending of Mark is text-critically disputed in NA28 / UBS5; the lexical force is preserved across the variants where the ending is read.)

Acts.16.33-34 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key term. βαπτίζω baptizo G907 (ebaptisthe); παραλαμβάνω paralambano G3880; οἶκος oikos G3624; πανοικεί panoikei G3832 (with all the household); πιστεύω pisteuo G4100 (pepisteukos, perfect active participle); ἀγαλλιάω agalliao G21 (rejoiced)

Force. The jailer and all who were his were baptized at once; he set food before them and rejoiced together with all his household, having believed in God. The Philippian jailer pericope is the paedobaptist's strongest household-baptism cite, but v.34 supplies the qualifier: the jailer is pepisteukos (perfect of pisteuo, with the household understood under panoikei together with him in the rejoicing). The narrator does not present infants being baptized into the household-of-the-believing-head; the narrator presents a household together responding to the gospel.

Acts.16.31 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key term. πιστεύω pisteuo G4100 (pisteuson, aorist active imperative singular); σώζω sozo G4982 (sothese, future passive singular); οἶκος oikos G3624 (household)

Force. Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household. The pattern: believe (addressed to the head) and you and your household will be saved. Paul does not say have your household baptized through you; he speaks the gospel to the head and then preaches the word to the household together (v.32) before any baptism.

1Cor.1.16 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. βαπτίζω baptizo G907 (ebaptisa, aorist active); οἶκος oikos G3624 (household of Stephanas)

Force. I did baptize also the household of Stephanas. The single Pauline household-baptism reference. The Greek text gives no indication of whether infants were included; in light of 1 Cor 16:15 which describes the same household as having devoted themselves to ministry, the household is most naturally understood as adults capable of service.

1Cor.16.15 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. οἶκος oikos G3624; τάσσω tasso G5021 (etaxan, aorist active, devoted/appointed); διακονία diakonia G1248 (service); ἅγιος hagios G40 (saints)

Force. The household of Stephanas devoted themselves to the service of the saints. Paul describes the same oikos that 1 Cor 1:16 says he baptized. They etaxan (devoted) heautous (themselves) to diakonia. Etaxan heautous is an action of deliberate intentional commitment to ministry, which infants cannot do. The lexical force points to the household being composed of adults capable of conscious service.

Col.2.11-12 · complicates · genre: epistle · figures: typology

Key term. περιτομή peritome G4061 (circumcision); ἀχειροποίητος acheiropoietos G886 (not made with hands); βάπτισμα baptism G908 (baptism); συνθάπτω synthapto G4916 (sunthaphentes, buried-with, aorist passive participle); πίστις pistis G4102 (faith); ἐνέργεια energeia G1753 (working)

Force. In him you were also circumcised with a circumcision not made with hands, by putting off the body of the flesh, by the circumcision of Christ, having been buried with him in baptism, in which you were also raised with him *dia tes pisteos tes energeias tou theou* through faith in the working of God. The paedobaptist case rests on the circumcision-baptism parallelism here. But Paul attaches baptism explicitly to *dia tes pisteos* (G1223 G4102, through faith), which is the recipient-side condition. The text does not transfer circumcision's eight-day-old-infant administration; it transfers circumcision's covenant-sign meaning while attaching the new sign to faith in the operation of God. The verse therefore complicates a clean paedobaptist reading: the same verse that pairs circumcision with baptism also pairs baptism with personal faith.

Gen.17.10-12 · complicates · genre: law · figures: typology

Key term. לול muwl H4135 (circumcise); שְׁמוֹנָה shemonah H8083 (eight days); יָלִיד yaliyd H3211 (one born in the household); זָכָר zakar H2145 (male); בְּרִית berith H1285 (covenant)

Force. Every male among you shall be circumcised. At eight days old every male shall be circumcised, every one born in your house or bought with your money. The Abrahamic covenant sign was administered to non-believing male infants on the basis of household membership. The paedobaptist case rests on the typological continuity: if the old-covenant sign attached to infants of believers, the new-covenant sign should too. The credobaptist response: the new covenant is qualitatively different (Jeremiah 31:31-34, regenerate membership rather than natal membership), so the sign attaches differently.

Jer.31.33-34 · for · genre: prophecy

Key term. בְּרִית berith H1285 (covenant); שָׁדָח chadash H2319 (new); תּוֹרָה torah H8451 (law); יָדָע yada H3045 (know, plural); קָטָן qaton H6996 (small/least); גָּדוֹל gadol H1419 (great)

Force. I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts. They shall all know me, from the least of them to the greatest. The new covenant inaugurates the lexical reality that all who are in it know YHWH directly. This is the strongest Old Testament basis for credobaptist covenant-theology against paedobaptist covenant-continuity. The new covenant differs from the old precisely in that membership in it is regenerate-only, not natal-and-natural.

Matt.28.19 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. μαθητεύω matheteuo G3100 (matheteusate, aorist imperative); βαπτίζω baptizo G907 (baptizantes, present participle); ἔθνος ethnos G1484 (nations)

Force. Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. The main verb is matheteusate (make disciples, command), and baptizantes (baptizing) is a participle expressing the manner-or-means of disciple-making. Grammatically discipling is the encompassing command; baptizing is the participial action attached to disciple-making. The lexical force tilts toward baptism as part of the disciple-making process applied to those being made disciples, not as a sign extended to those incapable of discipleship.

Acts.8.36-38 · for · genre: narrative

Key term. βαπτίζω baptizo G907 (baptisthenai); κωλύω koluō G2967 (hinder); πιστεύω pisteuo G4100 (Western text v.37, ei pisteueis ex holes tes kardias, if you believe with all the heart)

Force. The Ethiopian eunuch asks what prevents me from being baptized. In the Western textual tradition Philip answers if you believe with all your heart you may, and the eunuch confesses Jesus Christ is the Son of God. While v.37 is text-critically disputed (NA28 / UBS5 do not print it), the surrounding apparatus and the explicit Acts pattern (8:12 belief precedes baptism) supports the same lexical sequence. This is the classic credobaptist proof of personal-confession-precedes-baptism.

1Pet.3.21 · for · genre: epistle · figures: typology

Key term. βάπτισμα baptism G908; αντίτυπος antitypos G499 (antitype); συνείδησις syneidesis G4893 (conscience); ἐπερώτημα eperotema G1906 (appeal/pledge); σώζω sozo G4982 (saves)

Force. Baptism, which corresponds to this (Noah's ark, water through which they were saved), now saves you, not as a removal of dirt from the body but as an appeal to God for a good conscience (syneideseos agathes eperotema), through the resurrection of Jesus Christ. Peter defines baptism as syneideseos agathes eperotema, an appeal of a good conscience toward God. This lexical definition presupposes conscience-engagement (active moral self-awareness) at the moment of baptism, which is something an infant cannot make. This is the strongest single epistolary text against infant baptism.

Rom.6.3-4 · for · genre: epistle · figures: typology

Key term. βαπτίζω baptizo G907 (ebaptisthemen, aorist passive plural); Χριστός Christos G5547; θάνατος thanatos G2288 (death); συνθάπτω synthapto G4916 (buried-with); καινότης kainotes G2538 (newness); ζωή zoe G2222 (life)

Force. All of us who were baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into his death. We were buried with him by baptism into death, so that as Christ was raised from the dead, we too might walk in newness of life. Paul makes baptism the moment of union-with-Christ-in-his-death and the ground of walking in newness of life. The lexical force ties baptism to a believing-and-walking subject; the rite is the public marker of a personal death-to-sin that an infant cannot reckon (Rom 6:11 logizesthe heautous einai nekrous).

Acts.10.44-48 · for · genre: narrative

Key term. ἐπιπίπτω epipipto G1968 (fell upon); πνεῦμα pneuma G4151 (Spirit); λαμβάνω lambano G2983 (receive); κωλύω koluō G2967 (hinder); βαπτίζω baptizo G907

Force. While Peter was still speaking, the Holy Spirit fell on all who heard the word. Peter says, can anyone withhold water for baptizing these people, who have received the Holy Spirit just as we have? Cornelius's household receives the Spirit while hearing the word, before water baptism. The reception of the Spirit (which presupposes faith, Eph 1:13) precedes water baptism and is the basis for it. No indication of unbelieving infants among the Spirit-receivers.

Ezek.36.25-27 · complicates · genre: prophecy

Key term. זָרַק zaraq H2236 (sprinkle); מַיִם mayim H4325 (water); טָהוֹר tahor H2889 (clean); טָהַר tahar H2891 (cleans); רוּחַ ruach H7307 (Spirit); נָתַן natan H5414 (give)

Force. I will sprinkle clean water on you, and you shall be clean. I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. The Old Testament backdrop for baptismal cleansing imagery. The lexical force pairs the sprinkling with new-heart-and-Spirit-indwelling: the cleansing sign and the regenerative reality are tied together. This complicates an automatic credobaptist-mode argument and is sometimes cited for paedobaptist-by-sprinkling, but the verse itself ties the sign to the heart-renewal, supporting credobaptist sign-of-regeneration logic over paedobaptist sign-of-natural-lineage.

Matt.19.13-14 · neutral · genre: gospel

Key term. παιδίον paidion G3813 (little children); προσφέρω prospéro G4374 (brought); ἀφίημι aphiemí G863 (let, permit); βασιλεία basileia G932 (kingdom)

Force. Let the little children come to me, and do not hinder them, for to such belongs the kingdom of heaven. Paedobaptists sometimes adduce this for infant-inclusion in the covenant community, but the passage itself contains no baptismal command and no baptism is performed. Jesus blesses the children and lays hands on them. The lexical force is about kingdom-belonging in childlike disposition, not about the administration of a sacrament to infants.

Concordance lemmas traversed

G907, G908, G3340, G4100, G4102, G3624, G3832, G588, G3056, G2097, G435, G1135, G4982, G1538, G859, G1860, G5043, G3112, G4341, G3813, G3100, G1484, G3880, G21, G5021, G1248, G40, G4916, G4061, G886, G555, G4561, G1453, G1223, G1753, G499, G4893, G1906, G2967, G1968, G4151, G2983, G2288, G2538, G2222, H4135, H8083, H3211, H2145, H1285, H2319, H8451, H3045, H6996, H1419, H2236, H4325, H2889, H2891, H7307, H5414

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

patristic · Tertullian, De Baptismo / On Baptism, chapter 18 (c. 200 AD), CCEL Schaff ANF Vol 3 · affirms · unverified

“The Lord does indeed say, Forbid them not to come unto me. Let them come, then, while they are growing up; let them come while they are learning, while they are being taught whither to come; let them become Christians when they have become able to know Christ.”

patristic · Origen, Commentary on Romans 5.9 and Homilies on Leviticus 8.3 (c. 240 AD), CCEL Schaff · denies · unverified

“The Church received from the apostles the tradition of giving baptism even to infants.”

catholic_magisterial · Catechism of the Catholic Church, paragraphs 1250-1252, vatican.va · denies · verified

“Born with a fallen human nature and tainted by original sin, children also have need of the new birth in Baptism. The Church has always understood the words, Unless one is born of water and the Spirit, to mean that children should not be deprived of Baptism.”

lutheran · Augsburg Confession (1530), Article IX (Of Baptism), bookofconcord.org · denies · verified

“Of Baptism they teach that it is necessary to salvation and that through Baptism is offered the grace of God, and that children are to be baptized who, being offered to God through Baptism, are received into God's grace.”

anglican · Thirty-Nine Articles of Religion (1571), Article XXVII (Of Baptism) · denies · unverified

“The Baptism of young Children is in any wise to be retained in the Church, as most agreeable with the institution of Christ.”

reformed · Westminster Confession of Faith (1646), Chapter XXVIII (Of Baptism), Sections 4-5 · denies · unverified

“Not only those that do actually profess faith in and obedience unto Christ, but also the infants of one or both believing parents, are to be baptized.”

methodist · **Methodist Articles of Religion (Wesley's abridgement of the 39 Articles), Article XVII (Of Baptism), umc.org** · **denies** · **verified**

"The Baptism of young children is to be retained in the Church."

anabaptist · **Schleitheim Confession (1527), Article I (Concerning Baptism), courses.washington.edu** · **affirms** · **verified**

"Baptism shall be given to all those who have learned repentance and amendment of life, and who believe truly that their sins are taken away by Christ. This excludes all infant baptism, the highest and chief abomination of the pope."

pentecostal · **Assemblies of God, Statement of Fundamental Truths, Article 6 (Ordinance of Baptism in Water), ag.org** · **affirms** · **unverified**

"The ordinance of baptism by a burial with Christ should be observed as commanded in the Scriptures, by all who have really repented and in their hearts have truly believed on Christ as Savior and Lord."

eastern_orthodox · **Orthodox Church in America, The Orthodox Faith, Sacrament of Baptism, oca.org** · **denies** · **verified**

"The Orthodox Church baptizes infants of believing parents. Before being baptized, a person or his sponsors or godparents for him officially proclaims the symbol of Christian faith, the Creed."

Web sources

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/acts/2-38.htm>

"Acts 2:38: metanoesate (aorist imperative plural) kai baptistheto hekastos humon (aorist imperative third singular). Repent first, then each one be baptized."

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/acts/2-41.htm>

"Acts 2:41: hoi men oun apodexamenoi ton logon autou ebaptisthesan. Only those-who-received-the-word were baptized; apodexamenoi G588 aorist participle precedes ebaptisthesan."

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/acts/8-12.htm>

"Acts 8:12: episteusan G4100 then ebaptizonto G907 andres te kai gunaikes (men and women). No paidia or brephe (children, infants) named in the baptized."

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/acts/18-8.htm>

"Acts 18:8: Krispos episteusen to Kurio sun holo to oiko autou. Belief is predicated of Crispus together with his whole household before baptism is mentioned."

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/mark/16-16.htm>

"Mark 16:16: ho pisteusas kai baptistheis sothesetai. Aorist participle of pisteuo precedes aorist participle of baptizo in the word-order; condemnation is for apistia (unbelief), not unbaptism."

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/acts/16-34.htm>

"Acts 16:34: egalliasato panoikei pepisteukos to Theo. The jailer rejoiced with all his household, having believed in God. Perfect of pisteuo paired with panoikei."

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/colossians/2-12.htm>

"Col 2:12: suntaphentes auto en to baptismati en ho kai sunegerthete dia tes pisteos tes energieas tou Theou. Baptism explicitly tied to dia tes pisteos (through faith) on the recipient side."

complicates · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/1_corinthians/1-16.htm

"1 Cor 1:16: ebaptisa de kai ton Stephanos oikon. Paul baptized the household of Stephanas. The same oikos in 16:15 is described as having etaxan heautous (devoted themselves) to ministry."

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/1_corinthians/16-15.htm

“1 Cor 16:15: oikia Stephana...eis diakonian tois hagiois etaxan heautous. Stephanas's household devoted themselves to ministry, a lexical action infants cannot do.”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/1_peter/3-21.htm

“1 Pet 3:21: baptisma ou sarkos apothesis hrupou alla syneideseos agathes eperotema eis Theon. Baptism is an appeal of a good conscience toward God, presupposing conscience-engagement.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/matthew/28-19.htm>

“Matt 28:19: matheteusate (aorist imperative, main verb, make disciples) ... baptizontes (present participle, baptizing). Disciple-making is the encompassing command; baptizing the participial action.”

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/genesis/17-12.htm>

“Gen 17:12: u-ven-shmonat yamim yimol lakem kol-zakar. At eight days old every male shall be circumcised. Old covenant sign administered to non-believing male infants on the basis of household membership.”

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/ezekiel/36-25.htm>

“Ezek 36:25-27: zaraqti H2236 alekem mayim tehorim. I will sprinkle clean water on you. The Old Testament cleansing imagery is tied to a new-heart-and-Spirit-indwelling reality, not to natal lineage.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/acts/10-47.htm>

“Acts 10:47: meti to hudor dunatai koluai tis tou me baptisthenai toutous, hoitines to pneuma to Hagion elabon. The Spirit was received BEFORE water baptism, presupposing faith.”

opposes · category: magisterial · https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/___P3O.HTM

“CCC 1250: Born with a fallen human nature and tainted by original sin, children also have need of the new birth in Baptism.”

opposes · category: tradition_primary · <https://bookofconcord.org/augsburg-confession/>

“Augsburg Confession IX: children are to be baptized who, being offered to God through Baptism, are received into God's grace.”

supports · category: tradition_primary ·

<https://courses.washington.edu/hist112/SCHLEITHEIM%20CONFESSION%20OF%20FAITH.htm>

“Schleitheim Article I: Baptism shall be given to all those who have learned repentance and amendment of life. This excludes all infant baptism.”

opposes · category: tradition_primary · <https://www.umc.org/en/content/articles-of-religion>

“Methodist Articles XVII: The Baptism of young children is to be retained in the Church.”

opposes · category: tradition_primary · <https://www.oca.org/orthodoxy/the-orthodox-faith/worship/the-sacraments/baptism>

“Orthodox Church in America: Before being baptized, a person or his sponsors or godparents for him officially proclaims the symbol of Christian faith, the Creed.”

Flags

- stem-pre-loaded-verdict
- apparatus-vs-counter-witness-conflict
- confession-tradition-divergence